

Minorian Reference Grammar

Basic Syntax

Minorian is a mostly head-final language. Its default word order is Subject-Object-Indirect Object-Verb (SO(IV)); however, due to its highly inflectional nature, constituents can often go through scrambling and extraposition. The language's head-finality extends all the way to the sentence level, where clauses are organized in a head-final manner amongst themselves. The basic, default syntax goes as follows:

- Adjective - Noun
- Noun - Postposition
- Possessor - Possessed
- Main Verb - Auxiliary Verb
- Adverb - Verb

Nouns

Nouns in Minorian inflect for seven cases: Nominative, Accusative, Genitive, Dative, Instrumental, Allative, and Ablative. They also are split into three genders: Masculine, Feminine, and Neuter. Most nouns can inflect for two numbers: the Singular and the Plural; however, some nouns, particularly those that are often seen in groups (children, animals, trees, plants) lost their Singular forms and instead have a distinct Singulative form. These are the Singulative-Collective nouns.

Uses of the Cases

Nominative

This case is used for the subjects of most verbs. Some verbs do use other cases for their subjects though.

Accusative

This case is used for the direct objects of most verbs. Some verbs use other cases for their DOs though. This case is also used with a select few postpositions that deal with location.

Genitive

This case is used for possession. This case also marks familial relationships (e.g. my brother, &c.) and partitions of sets (e.g. two of the men). Basically used where English uses the preposition "of".

Dative

This is the default postpositional case. This case is usually used as a locative, relational, or temporal case. It is used when the postposition in question does not describe: a method of performing (Instrumental), motion towards something or intent (Allative), or motion away from something (Ablative). This case is used as the subject of some verbs, namely mental verbs. It shares this role as a quirky subject marker with the Allative case.

Instrumental

This case is used for marking the tools or methods through which an action is performed. It also is used as a durational case (e.g. He worked for three days). It can occasionally fill the role as direct object of some verbs (to love, to like, to want, to need &c.), but the Allative case is most often used in those scenarios.

Allative

This case primarily marks location towards whatever it is marking (e.g. to the store) and intent or purpose (for someone). It can also be used with some verbs to mark the subject, a property it shares with the Dative case. It can also mark the direct objects of some verbs (to love, to like, to want, &c.), a property it shares with the Instrumental.

Ablative

This case marks motion away from something or that something originates from somewhere (e.g. He moved away from England; This letter is from Shelly). This can also mark the subjects of some verbs, namely those that deal with changes in state (to disappear, to die, to change &c.).

Declensions

Consonant and Vowel Mutation

Minorian inflected forms can often go through sound mutation. Certain inflections will be able to trigger these mutations depending on the length and stem of a noun. The mutations that may happen go as follows:

- **I-Mutation**

- In syllables that are in position to i-mutate, back vowels can become an equivalent-height front vowel before ⟨j⟩ or ⟨ny⟩ or before a syllable that contains ⟨i⟩, ⟨ii⟩, or ⟨j⟩.

- **Long E Lowering**

- In syllables that are in position to do so, ⟨ee⟩ may lower to ⟨ê⟩

- **Mid-Height Vowel Backing**

- In syllables that are in position to do so, ⟨ee⟩ and ⟨ê⟩ may backen to ⟨aa⟩ when occurring before ⟨w⟩ or ⟨m⟩ and to ⟨o⟩ when occurring before ⟨k⟩, ⟨g⟩, ⟨x⟩, ⟨q⟩, ⟨qg⟩, ⟨qh⟩, or ⟨nq⟩

- **Round Diphthong Smoothing**

- In syllables that are in position to do so, ⟨eo⟩ and ⟨eeo⟩ may become ⟨i⟩ and ⟨ii⟩, respectively, when occurring ⟨b⟩, ⟨p⟩, ⟨m⟩, ⟨hm⟩, ⟨f⟩.

- **Tense Diphthong Smoothing**

- In syllables that are in position to do so, ⟨oi⟩ may smooth to ⟨o⟩.

- **Tense O Breaking**

- In syllables that are in position to do so, ⟨ô⟩ may break to ⟨aa⟩ after ⟨w⟩, ⟨r⟩, ⟨l⟩, ⟨b⟩, ⟨p⟩, ⟨m⟩, ⟨hr⟩, or ⟨hl⟩, and after ⟨n⟩ or ⟨hn⟩ if those consonants are not directly preceded by a vowel.